Kissing Doorknobs

By Terry Spencer Hesser

(Pg 12-13) *Step on a crack, break your mother's back!* The first time I heard that stupid rhyme was when I was eleven years old and still in possession of my own thoughts. At first I thought the rhyme was stupid.

But [then] I couldn't stop hearing it in my head over and over again. Eating dinner - Step on a crack, break your mother's back! Doing homework - Step on a crack, break your mother's back! Having a conversation - Step on a crack, break your mother's back! Falling asleep - Step on a crack, break your mother's back!

Nine syllables. Uneven. I hate that.

Not long after I heard that moronic rhyme for the first time, I suddenly couldn't take my eyes off the sidewalk. Anyone who saw me quietly counting cracks would know that something was seriously wrong with me.

To and from school. Counting. Sweating. And, of course, worrying. About my mother's spine. About my sanity. About being seen. And about being interrupted.

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INTRODUCTION

In adolescence, there are many things that seem out of my control - juggling school obligations, teacher and parent expectations, and finding time to just be a kid.

In the novel Kissing Doorknobs, based on real-life experiences, Tara has the same issues. Up until the time Tara was eleven years old, she thought her life was pretty much ordinary. Tall, blond, good grades, sister and parents, and enough anxieties to keep her company. But Tara's anxieties turned into rounds of habits that plagued her life and family, a result of OCD that wasn't diagnosed until after years of questioning her sanity.

Having no control in finding our solutions can be exhausting as seen in Kissing Doorknobs by Terry Spencer Hesser.

(Pg 18) [When I was little], I always woke up screaming from nightmare[s]. Usually, by the time I opened my eyes, my mother was already by my side, stoking my hair.

"I hate dream monsters too. But that's all they are. Dream monsters."

Letting kindness get that near to pain is like giving a fire some oxygen. Each time it happened, I

cried harder and harder as my eczema secretly spread to my torso. Eczema is a red, scaly rash that can crop up anywhere, anytime, and itch so badly that you want to scratch if off with a chain saw. My eczema, like my worries, seemed to come and go regardless of nightmares or the terrible kindness.

(Pg 20) Kindergarten was hell. After a few months, I got over my separation anxiety. But other things started to bother me. I lived in dread of fire drills and emergency evacuations.

(Pg 30) I worried so much that I worried about worrying.

(Pg 21) There were parent-teacher and counselor meetings about my fears, but no one seemed to feel confident about what to do. And so, unable to rely on adults in my life to save me, I turned my attention to God.

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(Pg 35-36) Then, one freezing day in winter, while waiting for the bell to ring, I heard someone say, "Step on a crack, break your mother's back!" and my entire life changed.

No matter how hard I tried, I couldn't not think the monotonous, scary refrain… and once I began to count cracks, I couldn't stop.

(Pg 44-45) [But] I decided to save as many souls as I could in my own small way. From that moment on, anytime anyone swore or took the Lord's name in vain, I said a prayer for their soul and punctuated my plea with the sign of the cross.

My family found my new quirk very irritating. My father tolerated it as another in my series of what he referred to as stages. My mother wasn't so philosophical. After a few months of it, she was pretty hostile.

Like the time she kicked the car door shut because she had groceries in both arms and got her

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skirt stuck in the door. "Son of a b--- already!" I instantly came to her aid.

"Our Father who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name…"

"Cut it out! Damn!"

This time [I] was silent. But she saw me make the sign of the cross.

"I'm warning you…"

Unpacking the groceries, my mother caught me murmuring a Hail Mary.

"Cut it out, Tara. PLEASE."

But I couldn't. "...and blessed is the fruit of thy womb…"

"Cut it out, I said! If I see you doing that one more time, I'm going to punish you… severely… Dammit!"

I was halfway through the sign of the cross and muttering an "Our Father…"

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(Pg 48) A few days later, my parents sent me to see a shrink. I'd been counting cracks for almost a year, but it was the praying that couldn't be tolerated. **(Pg 69)** I missed the way we all used to be, so badly that I felt sick.

(Pg 72) To take our minds off our problems, [my family] decided to go to a carnival together. [Earlier that day, my mother had told me,] **(Pg 71)** "I've been patient, but from now on, every time I see you make the sign of the cross, I'm going to slap you silly."

(Pg 72) Mounting the stairs to the Octopus ride, I reflexively performed a quick sign of the cross. I didn't even really know that I did it. But my mother did.

She grabbed my arm so violently I almost fell off the platform. "Do that on the ride and I'm going to kill you."

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(Pg 73) As the carnival worker strapped Greta and me in, my mother and I locked eyes. I crossed myself. Not just once but again and again for the duration of the ride.

"Why, Tara? Why?" was all my sister said, but I didn't answer her. I just kept praying and watching my mother even when we were upside down.

When the ride stopped, I knew I was a dead girl walking.

My mother picked me up by my arms, grabbed both my shoulders and shook me and shook me and shook me, crying harder than I did the entire time.

(Pg 88) For the most part, [by] eighth grade, I was normal. I rarely counted cracks or prayed anymore.

[For Christmas, my grandparents came over for dinner.] **(Pg 94)** The house smelled great, and everyone was standing around the table admiringly.

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(Pg 95-96) My dad said, "Okay, everybody can sit down where they're standing."

As everyone began to sit down, I went ballistic. "What's going on? Everybody is in the wrong places! You don't sit there! You sit there! Like always. Mom sits there like always! And Gramma and Grampa sit there, please! Please! Come on, Greta, you sit there like always… and [I] sit here… just like always! What's wrong with you guys? Huh? What are you trying to do to me! Come on, Daddy! Pleeeeeze sit there. Mom! Please! Please! Just like always! Just like always. It's got to be just like always!"

My grandparents looked more scared than I did. My mom's tears of pride had turned to fountains of pain. It was my father who spoke first. "Jesus, Mary and Joseph!"

"Our Father who art in Heaven -"…

"That's it!" My dad knocked a chair on its side and stormed out.

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(Pg 100) One day in late January, I stopped in front of the doorknob in our living room and… froze.

Before I knew what was happening, I had placed all ten of my fingers on the doorknob in a little circle with the exact same pressure… [and then] brought those fingers to my lips.

I spread my lips out as wide as I could and touched all ten of my fingers to my lips with the exact same pressure. It was the birth of a ritual that would be repeated many, many times. From that day on, I was compelled to perform that ritual almost any time I came in contact with my front door. If I slipped and applied more pressure with one finger than another, or if a finger fell off my lip, I'd have to do it all over again. **(Pg 134)** A new ritual.

(Pg 100) "Why? Why!? WHY?" my mother asked over and over, as if she was stuck on Replay.

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(Pg 110-111) It was a warm spring night and my dad was watching television. I was trying to get out the door so [I] could hang out at the park. Of course, in order to get out the front door, I had to touch the doorknob and my lips. Usually I had to do it thirty-three times. Thirty-three perfect times, and at least a half hour later than I'd planned on leaving, I could finally slip out. Usually. . . I felt [my father] staring at me.

"Was it something your mother and I did? Tara . . . please. I love you, Tara, We all do. Please stop. Please." The doorbell rang. My father and I were both startled. I didn't stop my ritual, although I did try to speed it up. Eighteen. Nineteen.

"Answer the door! Answer the damn door. Can't you just stop it for once? Stop it. Just stop it!"

I couldn't stop. I was so nervous I lost count just as he picked me up, moved me to the side and opened the door. It was Allan Jacobson, my

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father's old friend from college who was also the local high-school science teacher. As I looked at my dad's frightened face, I burst into tears. Giant tears. And my daddy took me in his arms and rocked me. Then he did something I'd never seen before. He began to cry too. We cried. And rocked. And cried.

After my dad and I calmed down, Mr. Jacobson started asking me questions that nobody had ever asked me before.

(Pg 112) "What does it feel like when you do that thing with the doorknob, honey? Do you do it a certain number of times? I have a boy in my class, a little older than you, who I think has a similar problem."

[My new therapist explained.] **(Pg 123-124)** "I'm sure she acts pretty crazy. Imagine how you'd act if you were trapped in an endless loop of repetitive obsessive thoughts accompanied by an anxiety so

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powerful you'd do anything . . . perform any compulsive act . . . just to make it go away. We don't know what causes it. Maybe genetics. Maybe stress, trauma, or other injury. Although the behavior has been around as long as man, the research is new. The longer a person has been a slave to OCD, the harder it is to make him or herself risk freedom. Why don't we move ahead with behavior therapy. If that proves inadequate on its own, then we'll consider medication."

(Pg 132-134) No matter how passionate I was, or how strong I decided to be, behavior therapy was very, very hard. I lost a lot of battles. It had been months and I was still involved in a terrible thirty-three-step dance involving my lips, fingers, and a doorknob. I also still counted cracks and prayed. Not all the time. But enough of the time to doubt that I'd ever win the war for my freedom.

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And on the good days, when I felt as if I was making progress - I was scared then, too.

[Walking home with my friends one day], I stepped on every crack I could find. I felt nervous, dizzy, sick, but I did it.

When we passed the hardware store, I ran inside. Standing in front of a wall of doorknobs, as a test, I ran my hand across a few of the doorknobs. I felt nothing.

(Pg 18) [When I was little], I always woke up screaming from nightmare[s].

(Pg 142) I think I figured out my dream. As I look at it now, it's kind of obvious. That monster was my OCD. It came out of nowhere, blocked out my world and threatened to crush me. I was paralyzed.

(Pg 148) But [I] didn't fold or drop out. [I] summoned the courage to play the cards life had

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dealt [me]. Reluctant, insecure warrior but warrior all the same. And [I'm not] alone.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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